

(2026 Revised) LIA Program description

Latinos In Action (LIA) is an elective course designed to empower students to discover their strengths, develop leadership skills, and create positive change in their communities. Through an asset-based approach, LIA recognizes that students' identities, experiences, backgrounds, and talents are valuable strengths that contribute to their success. The program helps students understand who they are, explore future opportunities, and connect their interests to careers and community service. Through career exploration, academic skill-building, service learning, and professional experiences, students develop the skills and confidence needed for success in school, college, careers, and life.

Tutoring will be conducted through two means: A letter exchange with check-ins with the elementary school partner as well as through hosting and volunteering at various literacy nights for the partner elementary school

This year we will focus on four key areas that align with Portrait of a Graduate:

1. **Personal and Cultural Assets***: Students identify their strengths, interests, values, and experiences while recognizing the unique contributions they bring to their communities.
2. **Academic Excellence**: Students build skills in goal setting, organization, research, communication, and problem-solving to support success in school and future goals.
3. **Community Service**: Students explore community needs and use their skills to create meaningful service projects that make a difference.
4. **Leadership Development**: Students develop confidence, teamwork, communication, and leadership skills through collaboration, presentations, and real-world experiences.

Throughout the year, students will create a personal portfolio that documents their growth, including reflections, career exploration activities, research projects, resumes, leadership experiences, service projects, and future goals. By the end of the program, students will better understand who they are, what they can achieve, and how they can use their strengths to lead and serve their communities.

Proposed Guest Speakers & Special Events Timeline

Event	Month	Purpose
Community Engagement Professional	September	Introduce service, community needs, and careers connected to helping others
Elementary Partnership Kickoff		Begin literacy mentorship letter exchange
College Tour 1 Trunk or Treat	October	Explore educational pathways and future opportunities Meet your buddy and Book Giveaway
Family Literacy Night #1 Dia de los Muertos @ Kaneshville or Roy Library	November	Community Engagement Bilingual reading night
College Guest Speakers		Connect education, careers, and service
STEM Professionals	December	Explore innovation careers and problem-solving
Career & Literacy Night	January	Connect literacy, careers, and future goals
Business/Industry Professionals		Explore career pathways and community impact
Public Service Professional		Explore careers focused on serving others
Project Manager/Professional Leader	February–March	Develop leadership and project management skills
Elementary Literacy Celebration		Celebrate mentorship, writing growth, and student leadership
Job Site Visit	April	Experience professional environments

Service Project Implementation Celebrating Growth		Celebrate student achievements and Apply learning through action community partnerships
Bilingual Literacy Night #2:	May	Community Engagement Bilingual reading night Close mentorship letter exchanges
Year-End Portfolio Celebration		Recognize student growth and leadership

Program Outcomes

Personal Growth

- Understand their strengths, identities, and interests
- Recognize the value of their experiences and backgrounds
- Develop confidence in their abilities

Academic Excellence

- Strengthen reading, writing, research, and communication skills
- Apply academic skills to real-world situations
- Develop organization and goal-setting habits

Career Awareness

- Explore careers connected to personal interests and community needs
- Understand education and career pathways
- Recognize careers as opportunities to create impact

Leadership Development

- Communicate professionally
- Lead collaborative projects
- Mentor younger students
- Develop confidence as community leaders

Community Service

- Identify community needs
- Complete meaningful service projects
- Understand the importance of serving others

Literacy Leadership

- Improve writing and communication skills
- Build relationships with elementary students
- Use literacy as a tool for empowerment and opportunity

Unit 1: Self-Discovery & Community Awareness

September: Building Identity, Service, and Literacy Connections

Unit Purpose

Students begin by understanding themselves—their strengths, interests, values, and goals. They connect their personal identities to community needs and begin developing relationships with elementary students through literacy mentorship.

Essential Question: “Who am I, and how can I use my strengths to make a difference?”

Students explore:

Strengths

Interests

Values

Goals

Future possibilities

Students complete:

Career interest assessments

Personality assessments

Strengths assessments

Reflection activities

Students discuss:

What am I naturally good at?

What interests me?

What values guide my choices?

How can my talents help others?

Portfolio 1: Personal Strength Profile

Include: Personal strengths

Career interests

Goals for the year

Possible ways to serve others

Community Awareness and Literacy Leadership Introduction

Focus: Students explore how their strengths and future careers can address community needs.

Students investigate:

Local challenges

Community resources

Service opportunities

Importance of literacy and education

Topics may include:

Education access

Environmental challenges

Health and wellness

Community support

Youth mentorship

Elementary Letter Exchange Program Begins

LIA students partner with elementary students to strengthen literacy skills while developing leadership and mentoring abilities.

First Letter Exchange: **Introduction Letters**

LIA students write letters introducing themselves.

Students include:

Name and interests

Strengths

Hobbies

Future goals

Favorite books

Advice for younger students??

Skills practiced:

Letter structure

Writing for an audience

Professional communication

Portfolio 2: Professional Introduction Letter

Guest Speaker: Community Engagement Professional

Students learn about: Community challenges, Service opportunities, Careers connected to helping others

Unit 2: Academic Habits Through Service

October–November: Building Research, Literacy, and Organization Skills

Unit Purpose: Students develop academic habits by applying them to meaningful projects. Research, writing, organization, and communication skills become tools for understanding problems and creating solutions.

Essential Question: **"How can I use what I learn in school to help solve real problems?"**

Students learn:

- Time management
- Organization systems
- Study strategies
- Goal setting
- Collaboration

Students create:

- A goal for improving learning habits.
- A goal connected to helping others.

Community Research Begins: Students select a community issue connected to their interests.

Students practice:

- Research skills
- Source evaluation
- Note-taking

Summarizing information

Written communication

College Tour

Explore:

College environments

Educational pathways

Career opportunities

Research and Solution Planning

Students identify:

- What is the issue?
- Who is affected?
- Why does it matter?
- What solutions are possible?

Portfolio Products 3

- Research notes
- Issue summary
- Service project ideas

Elementary Letter Exchange Connection

LIA students write elementary partners about:

- Study habits
- Organization strategies
- Goal setting
- Learning tips

Elementary students respond with:

- Their goals
- Questions
- What is happening in school?

Family Literacy Night @ Kaneshville or Library Families participate in:

- Reading activities
- Student presentations
- Community conversations

College and Career Connections

Guest speakers discuss:

- Educational pathways
- Career preparation
- Service-oriented careers

Students refine:

- Service proposals
- Research projects
- Portfolio entries

Unit 3: Career Exploration & Community Connection

December–January: Exploring Careers That Create Impact

Unit Purpose

Students discover how careers contribute to communities and connect their interests to future possibilities.

Essential Question: **"How can my future career help others?"**

STEM Careers and Innovation

Students examine:

- Career responsibilities
- Required skills
- Community impact

Student Reflection: **"How could this career help solve problems in my community?"**

December Literacy Exchange

Students write about:

- Future careers
- Personal goals
- Educational pathways
- Dreams for the future

Elementary students respond with:

- Career interests
- Questions
- Future dreams

Guest Speakers: STEM professionals

Business, Industry, Public Service, and Arts Career Research

Business and Industry

- Architecture
- Electrical work
- Entrepreneurship
- Graphic Design
- Veterinary Science

Public Service

- Educators
- Detectives
- Lawyers
- Military professionals
- Paramedics
- Social workers

Arts and Humanities

- Artists
- Translators
- Dance educators
- Travel professionals

Students explore: "**How do professionals strengthen communities?**"

Literacy Night #2

Students showcase:

- Career research/stations
- Community connections
- Elementary partnership activities
- Reading activities
- Student presentations

Unit 4: Professional Skills in Action

February–March: Preparing for the Workplace and Service Leadership

Unit Purpose

Students develop professional skills and learn how to organize, communicate, and lead meaningful projects. Students apply workplace skills while preparing to implement their community service projects.

Essential Question: "**What skills do professionals use to create change?**"

Focus: Students learn the professional skills needed for success in careers, college, and community leadership.

Skills Developed

Students practice:

- Resume writing
- Professional communication
- Email etiquette
- Interview skills
- Digital collaboration
- Teamwork
- Problem-solving
- Workplace expectations

Portfolio Products 4 : **Resume Draft, Professional Communication Sample**

Leadership Letters

LIA students write encouragement letters to elementary partners.

Topics may include:

- Being a leader
- Setting goals
- Building confidence
- Overcoming challenges

- Importance of education

Guest Speaker: Project Manager or Professional Leader

Planning strategies

Organization systems

Timeline development

Team roles

Problem-solving

Communication strategies

Student Service Project Planning

- Project timeline
- Team assignments
- Materials list
- Budget considerations
- Communication plan
- Community outreach plan

Service Project Implementation

- Launch service activities
- Work collaboratively
- Communicate with community partners
- Solve problems
- Document progress

Portfolio Products # 5

- Photos
- Reflection notes
- Service hours
- Community feedback
- Impact data

Literacy Event #3

Elementary Literacy Celebration & Letter Exchange Showcase

Purpose:

Celebrate student growth in communication, writing, and mentorship.

Activities:

- LIA students share highlights from the letter exchange
- Elementary students showcase writing pieces
- Students discuss the importance of literacy
- Families and educators celebrate student partnerships

Student Reflection: **"How has helping others strengthened my own learning?"**

Unit 5: Professional Communication & Service Implementation

April: Presenting Ideas and Celebrating Growth

Unit Purpose: Students practice communicating professionally and sharing their learning with families, community members, and younger students.

Essential Question: **"How do I communicate my ideas and demonstrate leadership?"**

Communication Skills

- Public speaking
- Presentations
- Interviews
- Storytelling
- Resume refinement
- Professional introductions

Career and Leadership Presentations

Students prepare presentations about:

- Community issue research
- Career connections
- Service project plans
- Personal growth

Job Site Visit

Students reflect: **"What professional skills did I observe?"**

Bilingual Literacy Night: Celebrating Growth

Families are invited to celebrate:

- Student leadership
- Career exploration
- Service projects
- Literacy partnerships

Activities include:

- Student presentations

- Bilingual reading activities
- Elementary student writing displays
- Career exploration stations
- Community partner recognition

Final Reflection Letters

Students write final letters sharing:

- What they learned
- Advice for younger students
- Appreciation for their partnership
- Goals for the future

Students reflect on:

- Growth as writers
- Growth as leaders
- Impact as mentors

Elementary Partnership Reflection

Students evaluate:

- How did I support younger students?
- How did my writing improve?
- What leadership skills did I develop?
- What impact did our partnership create?

Students evaluate:

- Year long Project successes
- Challenges overcome
- Skills developed
- Community impact
- Personal growth

Final Portfolio Requirements

Personal Growth

- Strength profile
- Personal reflections
- Goal progress

Academic Excellence

- Research project
- Writing samples
- Career reflections

Professional Skills

- Resume
- Communication samples
- Presentation materials

Leadership and Service

- Service project documentation
- Impact evidence
- Leadership reflections

Literacy Leadership

- Letter exchange samples
- Mentorship reflection
- Literacy event participation

Year-End Reflection

Personal Growth

- What did I discover about myself?
- What strengths did I develop?

Leadership

- How did I grow as a leader?
- How did I support others?

Community Impact

- How did I contribute to my community?
- What change did my service create?

Future Goals

- What careers connect to my passions?
- How will I continue creating impact?